

The Future Of Work - IELTS Reading Answers & Explanations

From [Cambridge IELTS 16 Academic Reading Test 1](#) · Part 3 · Questions 27–40

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Reading Passage

The future of work

According to a leading business consultancy, 3—14% of the global workforce will need to switch to a different occupation within the next 10—15 years, and all workers will need to adapt as their occupations evolve alongside increasingly capable machines. Automation — or ‘embodied artificial intelligence (AI)’ — is one aspect of the disruptive effects of technology on the labour market. ‘Disembodied AI’, like the algorithms running in our smartphones, is another.

Dr Stella Pachidi from Cambridge Judge Business School believes that some of the most fundamental changes are happening as a result of the ‘**algorithmicisation**’ of jobs that are dependent on data rather than on production — the so-called knowledge economy. Algorithms are capable of learning from data to undertake tasks that previously needed human judgement, such as reading legal contracts, analysing medical scans and gathering market intelligence.

‘In many cases, they can outperform humans,’ says Pachidi. ‘Organisations are attracted to using algorithms because they want to make choices based on what they consider is “perfect information”, as well as to reduce costs and enhance productivity.’

‘But these enhancements are not without consequences,’ says Pachidi. ‘If routine cognitive tasks are taken over by AI, how do professions develop their future experts?’ she asks. ‘One way of

learning about a job is “legitimate peripheral participation”— a novice stands next to experts and learns by observation. If this isn’t happening, then you need to find new ways to learn.’

Another issue is the extent to which the technology influences or even controls the workforce. For over two years, Pachidi monitored a telecommunications company. ‘The way telecoms salespeople work is through personal and frequent contact with clients, using the benefit of experience to assess a situation and reach a decision. However, the company had started using a[n] ... algorithm that defined when account managers should contact certain customers about which kinds of campaigns and what to offer them.’

The algorithm — usually built by external designers — often becomes the keeper of knowledge, she explains. In cases like this, Pachidi believes, a short-sighted view begins to creep into working practices whereby workers learn through the ‘algorithm’s eyes’ and become dependent on its instructions. Alternative explorations — where experimentation and human instinct lead to progress and new ideas — are effectively discouraged.

Pachidi and colleagues even observed people developing strategies to make the algorithm work to their own advantage. ‘We are seeing cases where workers feed the algorithm with false data to reach their targets,’ she reports.

It’s scenarios like these that many researchers are working to avoid. Their objective is to make AI technologies more trustworthy and transparent, so that organisations and individuals understand how AI decisions are made. In the meantime, says Pachidi, ‘We need to make sure we fully understand the dilemmas that this new world raises regarding expertise, occupational boundaries and control.’

Economist Professor Hamish Low believes that the future of work will involve major transitions across the whole life course for everyone: ‘The traditional trajectory of full-time education followed by full-time work followed by a pensioned retirement is a thing of the past,’ says Low. Instead, he envisages a multistage employment life: one where retraining happens across the life course, and where multiple jobs and no job happen by choice at different stages.

On the subject of job losses, Low believes the predictions are founded on a fallacy: 'It assumes that the number of jobs is fixed. If in 30 years, half of 100 jobs are being carried out by robots, that doesn't mean we are left with just 50 jobs for humans. The number of jobs will increase: we would expect there to be 150 jobs.'

Dr Ewan McGaughey, at Cambridge's Centre for Business Research and King's College London, agrees that 'apocalyptic' views about the future of work are misguided. 'It's the laws that restrict the supply of capital to the job market, not the advent of new technologies that causes unemployment.'

His recently published research answers the question of whether automation, AI and robotics will mean a 'jobless future' by looking at the causes of unemployment. 'History is clear that change can mean redundancies. But social policies can tackle this through retraining and redeployment.'

He adds: 'If there is going to be change to jobs as a result of AI and robotics then I'd like to see governments seizing the opportunity to improve policy to enforce good job security. We can "reprogramme" the law to prepare for a fairer future of work and leisure.' McGaughey's findings are a call to arms to leaders of organisations, governments and banks to pre-empt the coming changes with bold new policies that guarantee full employment, fair incomes and a thriving economic democracy.

'The promises of these new technologies are astounding. They deliver humankind the capacity to live in a way that nobody could have once imagined,' he adds. 'Just as the industrial revolution brought people past subsistence agriculture, and the corporate revolution enabled mass production, a third revolution has been pronounced. But it will not only be one of technology. The next revolution will be social.'

Questions

Questions 27–30 One Choice

Choose the correct letter, **A**, **B**, **C** or **D**.

Write the correct letter in boxes on your answer sheet.

27 The first paragraph tells us about

- A.** the kinds of jobs that will be most affected by the growth of AI.
- B.** the extent to which AI will alter the nature of the work that people do.
- C.** the proportion of the world's labour force who will have jobs in AI in the future.
- D.** the difference between ways that embodied and disembodied AI will impact on workers.

28 According to the second paragraph, what is Stella Pachidi's view of the 'knowledge economy'?

- A.** It is having an influence on the number of jobs available.
- B.** It is changing people's attitudes towards their occupations.
- C.** It is the main reason why the production sector is declining.
- D.** It is a key factor driving current developments in the workplace.

29 What did Pachidi observe at the telecommunications company?

- A.** staff disagreeing with the recommendations of AI
- B.** staff feeling resentful about the intrusion of AI in their work
- C.** staff making sure that AI produces the results that they want
- D.** staff allowing AI to carry out tasks they ought to do themselves

30 In his recently published research, Ewan McGaughey

- A.** challenges the idea that redundancy is a negative thing.
- B.** shows the profound effect of mass unemployment on society.
- C.** highlights some differences between past and future job losses.
- D.** illustrates how changes in the job market can be successfully handled.

Complete the summary using the list of words, **A-G**, below.

Write the correct letter, **A-G**, in boxes on your answer sheet.

- A** pressure **B** satisfaction **C** intuition
D promotion **E** reliance **F** confidence
G information

The 'algorithmication' of jobs

Stella Pachidi of Cambridge Judge Business School has been focusing on the 'algorithmication' of jobs which rely not on production but on 31 **G**.

While monitoring a telecommunications company, Pachidi observed a growing 32 **F** on the recommendations made by AI, as workers begin to learn through the 'algorithm's eyes'. Meanwhile, staff are deterred from experimenting and using their own 33 **C**, and are therefore prevented from achieving innovation.

To avoid the kind of situations which Pachidi observed, researchers are trying to make AI's decision-making process easier to comprehend, and to increase users' 34 **F** with regard to the technology.

Questions 35–40 Matching Features

Look at the following statements and the list of people below.

Match each statement with the correct person, **A**, **B** or **C**.

Write the correct letter, **A**, **B** or **C**, in boxes on your answer sheet.

NB You may use any letter more than once.

List of people

A Stella Pachidi

B Hamish Low

C Ewan McGaughey

35 Greater levels of automation will not result in lower employment. **R**

36 There are several reasons why AI is appealing to businesses. **A**

37 AI's potential to transform people's lives has parallels with major cultural shifts which occurred in previous eras. **C**

38 It is important to be aware of the range of problems that AI causes. **A**

39 People are going to follow a less conventional career path than in the past. **B**

40 Authorities should take measures to ensure that there will be adequately paid work for everyone **C**

Answers & Explanations Summary

#	Answer	Evidence	Explanation
Q27	B	Automation — or 'embodied artificial intelligence (AI)' — is one aspect of the disruptive effects of technology on the labour market.	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage talks about how technology, specifically embodied artificial intelligence (AI), is causing changes in the labor market. Answer Explanation: The answer choice 'B' refers to the extent to which AI will change the nature of work that people do. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is 'B' because the passage introduces the concept of embodied artificial intelligence and its disruptive effects on the labor market. This aligns with the idea that AI will significantly impact the nature of work carried out by people, showcasing the extent of change brought about by AI technology.
Q28	D	Algorithms are capable of learning from data to undertake tasks that previously needed human judgement, such as reading legal contracts, analysing medical scans and gathering market intelligence.	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage talks about how algorithms, which are computer programs, can now learn from data to perform tasks that previously required humans, like interpreting legal documents, analyzing medical images, and collecting market information. Answer Explanation: The answer choice D suggests that Stella Pachidi views the 'knowledge economy' as a significant factor that is currently driving changes in the workplace. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is D because the passage implies that the utilization of algorithms and data-driven tasks is a

#	Answer	Evidence	Explanation
			key driving force behind the changing dynamics in the workplace, reflecting a perspective aligned with the concept of the 'knowledge economy'.
Q29	C	the company had started using a[n] ... algorithm that defined when account managers should contact certain customers about which kinds of campaigns and what to offer them	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage talks about a telecommunications company using an algorithm to decide when employees should contact certain customers for specific marketing campaigns. Answer Explanation: The answer means that the staff is ensuring that the AI generates outcomes that align with their preferences or goals. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is C because in the excerpt, the AI is determining when account managers should contact customers. This implies that the staff is making sure that the AI produces the desired results, indicating that they are influencing the AI to carry out tasks based on what they want.
Q30	D	If there is going to be change to jobs as a result of AI and robotics then I'd like to see governments seizing the opportunity to improve policy to enforce good job security. We can "reprogramme" the law to prepare for a fairer future of work and leisure.	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage suggests that governments should make changes in laws to ensure better job security in the face of upcoming job changes due to AI and robotics. Answer Explanation: The answer indicates that Ewan McGaughey illustrates how changes in the job market can be successfully handled. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is 'D' because in the excerpt, McGaughey emphasizes the need for governments to adjust policies to ensure job security in the changing

#	Answer	Evidence	Explanation
			job landscape, indicating a proactive approach to handling changes in the job market.
Q31	G	Dr Stella Pachidi from Cambridge Judge Business School believes that some of the most fundamental changes are happening as a result of the ‘algorithmication’ of jobs that are dependent on data rather than on production — the so-called knowledge economy.	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage talks about how jobs are changing because they rely more on data than on physical production. Answer Explanation: The answer refers to 'information,' which is closely related to the use of data in modern jobs. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer 'G' corresponds to the concept of data and technology, which is highlighted in the excerpt through the mention of jobs dependent on data and the 'algorithmication' of jobs. The focus on making AI decision-making more understandable and increasing users' engagement with technology further supports the importance of 'information' in this context.
Q32	E	In cases like this, Pachidi believes, a short-sighted view begins to creep into working practices whereby workers learn through the ‘algorithm’s eyes’ and become dependent on its instructions.	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage talks about how workers start to rely heavily on the instructions provided by the algorithm they work with, rather than using their own judgment or input. Answer Explanation: The answer indicates the importance of users providing their own input or judgment, which is essential to avoid becoming overly reliant on AI technology. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is 'E - reliance' because the excerpt highlights the negative consequences of workers depending too much on the algorithm's

#	Answer	Evidence	Explanation
			instructions instead of using their own judgment or input. Therefore, emphasizing the need for users to rely on their own input is crucial to prevent overdependence on AI technology.
Q33	C	Alternative explorations — where experimentation and human instinct lead to progress and new ideas — are effectively discouraged.	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage mentions that when people experiment and follow their instincts, they can discover new ideas and make progress. Answer Explanation: The answer choice C (intuition) is correct because it refers to relying on one's instincts or gut feelings. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is C (intuition) because the excerpt talks about how the current situation discourages experimentation and human instinct, indicating that relying on intuition could lead to progress and new ideas, which is in contrast to the negative impact of the current reliance on AI algorithms mentioned in the passage.
Q34	F	Their objective is to make AI technologies more trustworthy and transparent, so that organisations and individuals understand how AI decisions are made.	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage talks about researchers working to make AI technologies easier for people to trust and understand, so that organizations and individuals can know how AI makes decisions. Answer Explanation: The answer, 'F', refers to confidence. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is 'confidence' because the researchers aim to instill trust and transparency in AI technologies. Building confidence in AI systems is crucial for users to understand and trust the decisions

#	Answer	Evidence	Explanation
			made by AI, as mentioned in the excerpt.
Q35	B	On the subject of job losses, Low believes the predictions are founded on a fallacy: 'It assumes that the number of jobs is fixed. If in 30 years, half of 100 jobs are being carried out by robots, that doesn't mean we are left with just 50 jobs for humans. The number of jobs will increase: we would expect there to be 150 jobs.'	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage talks about how Hamish Low believes that increasing automation will not lead to a decrease in employment. Low explains that if robots take over half of the existing jobs, he believes new jobs will be created, resulting in more overall jobs available. Answer Explanation: The answer indicates that the person who holds the belief that greater levels of automation will not lead to lower employment is Hamish Low (Choice B). Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is B because in the excerpt, it specifically states that Low argues against the idea that automation will result in job losses by emphasizing that the number of jobs is not fixed and that new jobs will be created alongside automation, potentially leading to more total jobs available in the future.
Q36	A	'In many cases, they can outperform humans,' says Pachidi. 'Organisations are attracted to using algorithms because they want to make choices based on what they consider is "perfect information", as well as to reduce costs and enhance productivity.'	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage talks about how businesses find AI appealing because AI can sometimes perform better than humans. Organizations like using algorithms to make decisions based on what they think is perfect information and to lower costs while increasing productivity. Answer Explanation: The answer choice A is related to Stella Pachidi, who is mentioned in the excerpt as stating reasons why organizations are attracted to using algorithms in their operations. Reason For Correctness:

#	Answer	Evidence	Explanation
			The correct answer is A because Stella Pachidi, mentioned in the excerpt, emphasizes the benefits of using algorithms in businesses, which aligns with the question regarding the appeal of AI to businesses.
Q37	C	‘The promises of these new technologies are astounding. They deliver humankind the capacity to live in a way that nobody could have once imagined,’ he adds. ‘Just as the industrial revolution brought people past subsistence agriculture, and the corporate revolution enabled mass production, a third revolution has been pronounced. But it will not only be one of technology. The next revolution will be social.’	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage talks about how new technologies have the potential to greatly improve the way people live, similar to how major cultural shifts in the past have transformed society. Answer Explanation: The answer suggests that Ewan McGaughey matches the statement about AI's potential to bring about significant changes in people's lives. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is C (Ewan McGaughey) because in the excerpt, the reference to a 'third revolution' that will not only be technological but also social aligns with the idea that AI has the potential to lead to broader societal changes, which is emphasized by Ewan McGaughey in the passage.
Q38	A	‘But these enhancements are not without consequences,’ says Pachidi. ‘If routine cognitive tasks are taken over by AI, how do professions develop their future experts?’ she asks.	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage talks about the potential consequences of AI taking over routine cognitive tasks. Stella Pachidi is emphasizing the importance of understanding how this shift may impact the development of future experts in various professions. Answer Explanation: The answer 'A' suggests that the person who believes it is important to be aware of the range of problems that AI causes is Stella Pachidi. Reason For Correctness:

#	Answer	Evidence	Explanation
			The correct answer is 'A' because Stella Pachidi, as mentioned in the excerpt, is highlighting the consequences of AI replacing routine cognitive tasks and raising a concern about how professions can nurture their future experts amidst these changes. This aligns with the idea that being aware of the problems AI brings is important, connecting the answer to the statement.
Q39	B	Economist Professor Hamish Low believes that the future of work will involve major transitions across the whole life course for everyone: 'The traditional trajectory of full-time education followed by full-time work followed by a pensioned retirement is a thing of the past,' says Low.	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage explains that according to economist Professor Hamish Low, the typical career path of going to school, working full-time, and then retiring with a pension is no longer common. Answer Explanation: The answer states that people are likely to choose a less traditional career path in the future. Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is B (Hamish Low) because Hamish Low, the economist mentioned in the excerpt, specifically talks about major transitions in work patterns, indicating that people will pursue non-conventional career paths in the future.
Q40	C	McGaughey's findings are a call to arms to leaders of organisations, governments and banks to pre-empt the coming changes with bold new policies that guarantee full employment, fair incomes and a thriving economic democracy.	Excerpt/Passage Explanation: The passage is saying that leaders should implement new policies to make sure that everyone has a job that pays fairly. Answer Explanation: The answer means that person C, Ewan McGaughey, is the one who supports the idea that authorities should take steps to guarantee there are good-paying jobs for everyone.

#	Answer	Evidence	Explanation
			Reason For Correctness: The correct answer is C because Ewan McGaughey is specifically mentioned as advocating for policies that ensure full employment and fair incomes in the excerpt provided, aligning with the statement about authorities taking measures to secure adequately paid work for all.